

This is no coming-of-age movie, but a deeply felt and realistic portrait that captures the pain and beauty of young life.

TEN CANOES

Rolf de Heer and Peter Djigirr, 2006

Ten Canoes was the first Australian movie ever made completely in an Aboriginal language, and with an exclusively Aboriginal cast. But it would be a mistake to think it was notable for these things alone. In fact, it is a charming and hugely imaginative movie in which there is rich complexity behind apparent simplicity. Set in the remote Arnhem Land, at first the story seems like a simple fable of young love, but with flashbacks to ancient times it becomes a mesh of different perspectives. The most modern time period is shot in black and white, while the past is brought to life in color, a beautifully simple idea that illustrates how the past can be as vital as the present. The movie is narrated by David Gulpilil, who starred in Nicolas Roeg's *Walkabout*, and one of the cast is Gulpilil's son Jamie.

THERE WILL BE BLOOD

Paul Thomas Anderson, 2007

At the heart of Paul Thomas Anderson's *There Will Be Blood* is a remarkable performance by Daniel Day-Lewis as Daniel Plainview, the silver miner turned oilman in his ruthless pursuit of wealth. To persuade small landowners to allow him to drill on their land, Plainview presents himself as a prophet of profit. He becomes so obsessed with finding oil and destroying his competitors that he is eventually

driven insane. The movie seems to get to the nub of capitalism's true nature: that, ultimately, it is about domination not profit.

THE SECRET IN THEIR EYES

Juan José Campanella, 2009

Retired Buenos Aires federal agent Benjamín (Ricardo Darín) is writing a novel, but has writer's block. So he calls on former colleague Irene (Soledad Villamil) to go over the details of a case they worked on together 25 years earlier. As Benjamin revisits the case, he rekindles a buried passion for Irene, as well as revealing the obsessions of the other people involved in the case. Campanella splits the action between the 1990s and the 1970s, a time of brutal military dictatorship, in which political murders were sanctioned by the state. The result is a movie that works both as a tightly scripted thriller with a very clever twist, and as a frank examination of Argentina's troubled recent past.

THE KID WITH A BIKE

Jean-Pierre and Luc Dardenne, 2011

The Kid With a Bike (*Le gamin au vélo*) is the tender story of 12-year-old Cyril (Thomas Doret) finding comfort with a young woman called Samantha (Cécile de France) who gives him a bicycle after his father abandons him. Samantha is in some ways a fairy godmother, but the Dardenne brothers' directing keeps the movie realistic. Their work owes a clear debt to neorealist classics about childhood such as *Kes* and *The Bicycle Thief*. In a departure from their previous, intensely naturalistic work, the

brothers used incidental music for this movie, explaining that its fairy-tale structure required it.

HOLY MOTORS

Leos Carax, 2012

Holy Motors, a fantasy drama by French director Leos Carax, has been described as a parable of human relationships for the internet age. It is a hard movie to pin down, however, and is certainly surreal. It follows businessman Monsieur Oscar (Denis Lavant), who is taken around Paris in a white limousine, driven by Céline (Edith Scob), entering a bizarre sequence of worlds and roles: as assassin, raging father, bag lady, and many more. It defies narrative logic, and seems to combine the worlds of Lewis Carroll with those of David Lynch and Luis Buñuel.

THE GRAND BUDAPEST HOTEL

Wes Anderson, 2014

In *The Grand Budapest Hotel*, Wes Anderson maintains his reputation for walking the line between folly and genius. Set in a fictional central European state between the two world wars, the story recounts in flashback the comic adventures of Gustave H. (Ralph Fiennes), a legendary concierge, and his trusted bellboy Zero Moustafa (Tony Revolori and F. Murray Abraham). The plot is driven by Gustave H.'s attempts to get his hands on a priceless painting, with the rise of fascism providing the background tension. The film is a fast-moving farce, a love story, and a lament for a vanished age of spa hotels and their eccentric guests.